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Political Science

# Contemporary South Asia

Unit III · Democracy, Conflict & Peace Initiatives in South Asia · CUET UG 2027 Complete Mastery

INSIDE
Concept Notes

INSIDE
Solved Examples

INSIDE
Practice MCQs + Solutions

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## Syllabus Alignment & Chapter Architecture

| Sub-Topic Domain | Official NTA CUET UG Unit III Syllabus Scope | High-Frequency Cognitive Skills Tested |
|---|---|---|
| **Defining South Asia** | Geographical and political definition; seven core states (India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Maldives); Afghanistan as 8th member (2007); non-inclusion of China; shared cultural ecology and natural boundaries. | Identifying regional geopolitical boundaries; evaluating geographic cohesion; analyzing shared cultural-civilizational identities. |
| **Pakistan: Army vs Democracy** | Military rulers: Ayub Khan (1958), Yahya Khan (1969), Zia-ul-Haq (1977), Pervez Musharraf (1999); civilian interludes: Z.A. Bhutto, Benazir Bhutto (PPP), Nawaz Sharif (PML-N); structural factors behind democratic fragility: military-clergy-landowner nexus, US/Cold War backing, Kashmir obsession. | Deconstructing systemic obstacles to constitutional democracy; analyzing civil-military relations; evaluating foreign geopolitical interventions. |
| **Bangladesh: Liberation & Democracy** | East Pakistan grievances: language discrimination, economic exploitation; Awami League 6-point charter; Sheikh Mujibur Rahman; 1971 military crackdown; Mukti Bahini; Indian intervention & Dec 1971 liberation; 1975 coup; Ershad regime (1982–90); democratic restoration (1991). | Tracing national liberation chronologies; analyzing constitutional transformations; evaluating transitions from autocracy to competitive democracy. |
| **Monarchy & Democracy in Nepal** | Historical Hindu Kingdom; 1990 popular movement for constitutional monarchy; triangular conflict: King vs Parliament vs Maoist insurgents; King Gyanendra's 2002/2005 royal takeover; April 2006 democracy movement (Seven-Party Alliance & Maoists); abolition of monarchy (2008); 2015 secular republic constitution. | Analyzing trajectories of democratic mobilization; evaluating monarchical vs popular legitimacy; examining peace accords with armed insurgencies. |
| **Sri Lanka: Ethnic Strife & Peace** | Sinhala majoritarianism; 'Sinhala Only Act' (1956); Tamil minority alienation; Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE, V. Prabhakaran); demand for Tamil Eelam; Indo-Sri Lanka Accord (1987) & IPKF intervention; assassination of Rajiv Gandhi (1991); military defeat of LTTE (May 2009); economic resilience. | Evaluating majoritarian democracy pathologies; analyzing sub-national separatist movements; assessing external third-party mediation. |
| **India's Bilateral Ties & SAARC** | Indo-Pak: Kashmir, Siachen, Sir Creek, nuclearization (Pokhran-II & Chagai, 1998), Kargil War (1999); Indo-Bangla: Farakka Ganga Accord (1996), enclaves exchange (2015); Nepal/Bhutan: 1950 Friendship Treaties; Maldives: Operation Cactus (1988); SAARC (Dhaka 1985); SAFTA (2004/2006); Gujral Doctrine. | Evaluating bilateral disputes and confidence-building measures (CBMs); analyzing regional economic integration; diagnosing structural constraints of SAARC. |

### CUET HIGH-SCORING INSIGHT & KEY COGNITIVE TRAPS

Theme 3 requires exact clarity regarding regional geographical definitions, institutional accords, and dates:

1. **What Constitutes 'South Asia' in NCERT:**
   - South Asia comprises **seven core countries**: India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives.
   - **Afghanistan** joined SAARC as the **eighth member** in **2007** (at the 14th Summit in New Delhi).
   - **China** is an immediate neighbor, but is strictly **NOT** considered part of South Asia in political science!
2. **Maldives Constitutional Chronology:**
   - Maldives was an Islamic **Sultanate** until **1968**, when it became a presidential republic.
   - Multi-party democracy was officially legalized in **June 2005**, leading to the election of Mohamed Nasheed (Maldivian Democratic Party) in 2008.
3. **SAARC and SAFTA Parameters:**
   - **SAARC:** Founded in **Dhaka** in **December 1985** with 7 members; permanent Secretariat is in **Kathmandu, Nepal**.
   - **SAFTA:** Signed at the 12th SAARC Summit in Islamabad in **January 2004**; became operational on **1 January 2006**.
4. **The Gujral Doctrine (1996):**
   - Formulated by External Affairs Minister I.K. Gujral under the United Front government.
   - Principles: With smaller neighbors (Bangladesh, Bhutan, Maldives, Nepal, Sri Lanka), India does **not seek reciprocity**, but gives what it can in good faith and trust without demanding equal return.

# 1. What is South Asia? Boundaries, Diversity and Democratic Aspirations

The geopolitical realm of South Asia represents a colossal civilizational space bounded by the natural ramparts of the Himalayas in the north and the expansive waters of the Indian Ocean, the Arabian Sea, and the Bay of Bengal in the south, west, and east:

## The Geopolitical Demarcation of the Region

- **The Eight Constituent Nations:** Contemporary South Asia encompasses eight sovereign states: **India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, the Maldives**, and **Afghanistan** (which joined the regional association SAARC in 2007).
- **Excluded Neighbors:** Although sharing extensive land borders, **China** and **Myanmar** belong geographically and politically to East Asia and Southeast Asia, respectively, and are not categorized as South Asian states.
- **Unity in Diversity:** The region is characterized by profound linguistic, religious, and cultural diversity, yet shares deep historical linkages, intertwined river basins (Indus and Ganga-Brahmaputra), and common post-colonial challenges of poverty alleviation, literacy, and public health.

### The Universal Aspiration for Democracy

A widespread myth in early Western political science asserted that democracy was a luxury that could flourish only in affluent, industrialized Western societies. A comprehensive cross-national survey conducted across five major South Asian nations in the 2000s completely dismantled this misconception:

- **Widespread Popular Support:** In India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, and Sri Lanka, ordinary citizens across every social stratum—rich and poor, rural and urban, educated and illiterate, regardless of religious affiliation—overwhelmingly preferred democracy over military dictatorship or authoritarian rule.
- **Indigenous Democratic Roots:** The desire for representative governance, fundamental freedoms, and responsive institutions is profoundly rooted in the collective consciousness of South Asian peoples.

## 2. Pakistan: The Oscillating Pendulum between Military Dictatorship and Democracy

Since achieving independence in 1947, Pakistan's constitutional evolution has been defined by chronic political instability, characterized by recurring military coups interspersed with fragile civilian democratic regimes:

### The Era of the Military Strongmen

1. **General Ayub Khan (1958–1969):** Following political factionalism and the breakdown of the 1956 Constitution, General Ayub Khan seized power in Pakistan's first military coup. He introduced a system of "Basic Democracies" but was forced to step down amidst massive popular protests against inflation and lack of representation.
2. **General Yahya Khan (1969–1971):** Ayub handed power to army chief General Yahya Khan. During Yahya's tenure, Pakistan's first general elections were held in December 1970. The refusal of West Pakistani elites to transfer power to the victorious East Pakistani Awami League triggered the brutal 1971 military crackdown, the Bangladesh Liberation War, and the catastrophic surrender of 93,000 Pakistani troops.
3. **General Zia-ul-Haq (1977–1988):** Following a brief civilian democratic interlude under **Zulfikar Ali Bhutto** (1971–1977), General Zia-ul-Haq deposed Bhutto in a coup and later had him executed. Zia enforced an aggressive, orthodox program of state Islamisation and leveraged Pakistan's role as a frontline ally of the United States in the anti-Soviet Afghan war to sustain his military rule.
4. **General Pervez Musharraf (1999–2008):** Following another decade of competitive civilian elections between **Benazir Bhutto** (Pakistan People's Party) and **Nawaz Sharif** (Pakistan Muslim League), army chief General Pervez Musharraf overthrew Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif in an October 1999 coup, following the Kargil conflict. Musharraf ruled as military President until popular agitations by the lawyers' movement and democratic parties forced his resignation in 2008.

### Structural Factors Behind the Fragility of Democracy

Why has democracy failed to institutionalize in Pakistan?

- **The Hegemony of the Military, Clergy and Landed Oligarchy:** The armed forces (**the Pakistan Army**) function as the dominant socio-economic institution, controlling vast commercial corporations, defense lands, and intelligence networks (**the ISI**). The military elite

routinely collaborates with conservative religious clergy and powerful feudal landlords to subvert elected civilian governments.

- **The Obsession with India and Kashmir:** The perpetual conflict with India over Jammu and Kashmir has been weaponized by military elites to justify massive defense spending and convince the public that only the army can safeguard national security.
- **Foreign Geopolitical Complicity:** Western powers—primarily the United States—have historically propped up Pakistani military dictatorships to serve Cold War and post-9/11 counter-terrorism objectives, fearing that a civilian breakdown might allow Pakistan's nuclear arsenal to fall into extremist hands.

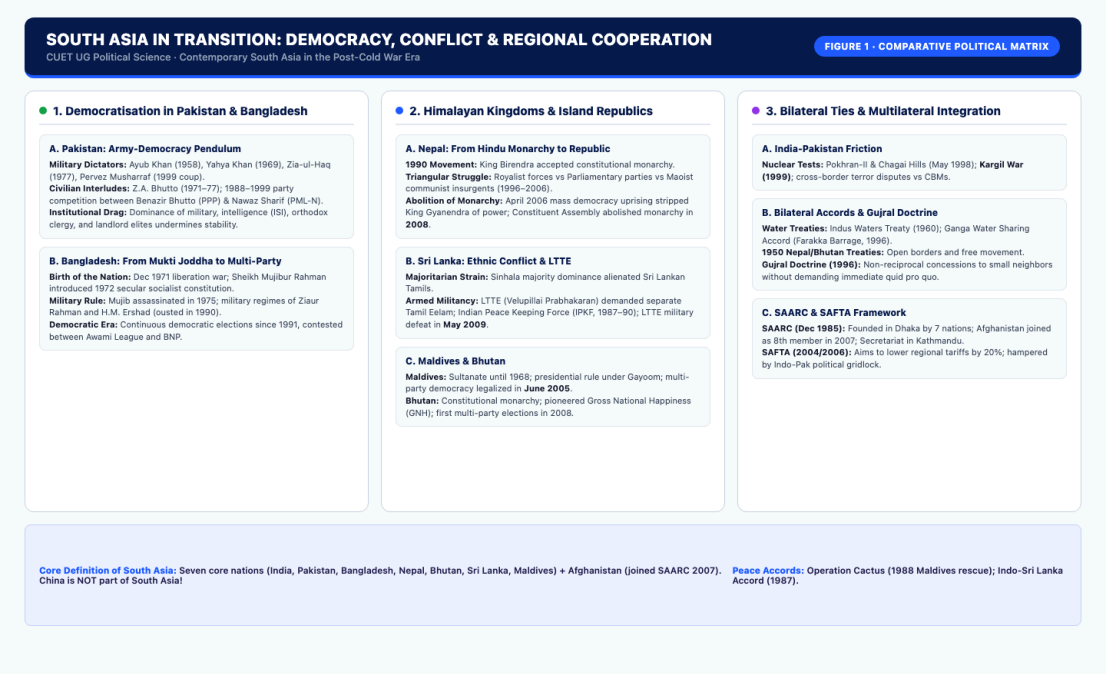



Figure 1: Figure 1 — South Asian Democratisation & Bilateral Architecture: Comparative matrix of civilian vs military regimes, Himalayan transitions, and Indo-neighbor bilateral frameworks.

# 3. Bangladesh: The Struggle from Liberation to Multi-Party Democracy

Bangladesh emerged as an independent sovereign republic through a heroic, bloody national liberation struggle against West Pakistani internal colonialism:

## The Roots of Bengali Grievances (1947–1971)

From 1947 to 1971, East Pakistan (modern Bangladesh) was subjected to systematic economic exploitation and political subjugation:

- **Linguistic and Cultural Suppression:** West Pakistani rulers attempted to force Urdu as the sole national language, sparking the historic **Bengali Language Movement** of 1952.
- **Economic Disparity:** While East Pakistan generated the vast majority of foreign exchange through jute exports, state development funds, industrial infrastructure, and senior civil/military appointments were monopolized by West Pakistan.
- **The Awami League's Six-Point Movement:** Led by the charismatic **Sheikh Mujibur Rahman** ("Bangabandhu"), the Awami League demanded complete regional autonomy based on a famous Six-Point program. In the December 1970 general elections, the Awami League swept 167 of the 169 seats in East Pakistan, winning an absolute majority in the all-Pakistan National Assembly.

- **Operation Searchlight and Liberation War:** Refusing to convene parliament, the military regime launched **Operation Searchlight** on 25 March 1971, slaughtering hundreds of thousands of unarmed Bengali intellectuals, students, and citizens. Over ten million refugees fled across the border into India. Led by the **Mukti Bahini** (liberation army) and supported by the Indian Armed Forces under Prime Minister Indira Gandhi, Pakistani forces were comprehensively defeated on **16 December 1971**, giving birth to independent Bangladesh.

### Constitutional Turbulence and the Return to Democracy

- **The Rise and Fall of Mujib:** Sheikh Mujib introduced a secular, socialist, democratic constitution. However, in 1975, amidst economic turmoil, Mujib amended the constitution to establish a one-party presidential regime (BAKSAL), banning opposition parties. In August 1975, military officers assassinated Mujib along with most of his family members.
- **Military Dictatorships:** Successive military officers—**Ziaur Rahman** (who founded the Bangladesh Nationalist Party, BNP) and **General H.M. Ershad**—ruled the country.
- **Restoration of Democracy (1990–1991):** Massive popular student and civilian protests forced General Ershad to resign in December 1990. In 1991, free multi-party parliamentary elections were restored, with power alternating primarily between the Awami League (led by Sheikh Hasina) and the BNP (led by Begum Khaleda Zia).

## 4. Monarchy and Republic in Nepal: The People's Triumph

For centuries, Nepal was a traditional, landlocked Hindu monarchy. In modern times, it witnessed a dramatic, protracted struggle between feudal autocracy, parliamentary parties, and radical armed revolution:

### The Evolution from Constitutional Monarchy to Direct Royal Rule

- **The 1990 Jan Andolan (Movement for Democracy):** In 1990, mass pro-democracy demonstrations compelled King Birendra to accept a democratic constitution, reducing the monarch to a constitutional head of state.
- **The Maoist Insurgency (1996–2006):** In 1996, the Communist Party of Nepal (Maoist), led by **Pushpa Kamal Dahal** ("Prachanda") and Baburam Bhattarai, launched an armed guerrilla war against the monarchy, feudal landlordism, and caste oppression, rapidly seizing control of rural hill districts.
- **The Royal Palace Massacre (June 2001):** King Birendra and his immediate family were killed in a tragic palace shooting, and his conservative brother **Gyanendra** ascended the throne.
- **Gyanendra's Royal Coup (2002/2005):** Citing the failure of parliamentary parties to quell the Maoist insurgency, King Gyanendra dismissed the elected Prime Minister in 2002, and in **February 2005** staged a direct royal coup, suspending the constitution, jailing political leaders, and assuming absolute autocratic power.

### The April 2006 Revolution and the Abolition of Monarchy

- **The Seven-Party Alliance (SPA) and Maoist Accord:** The seven major parliamentary parties joined hands with the underground Maoists in late 2005, signing a historic 12-point peace agreement in New Delhi to overthrow royal tyranny.
- **The Mass Uprising of April 2006:** Millions of citizens flooded the streets of Kathmandu in defiance of royal curfews. Realizing that the army could no longer contain the popular surge, King Gyanendra capitulated in April 2006, restoring the dissolved parliament.
- **Abolition of the Monarchy (2008):** The restored parliament stripped the king of all state powers and military command. In **2008**, the newly elected Constituent Assembly formally

**abolished the 240-year-old Hindu monarchy**, declaring Nepal a federal, secular, democratic republic. In 2015, Nepal adopted a comprehensive new secular democratic constitution.

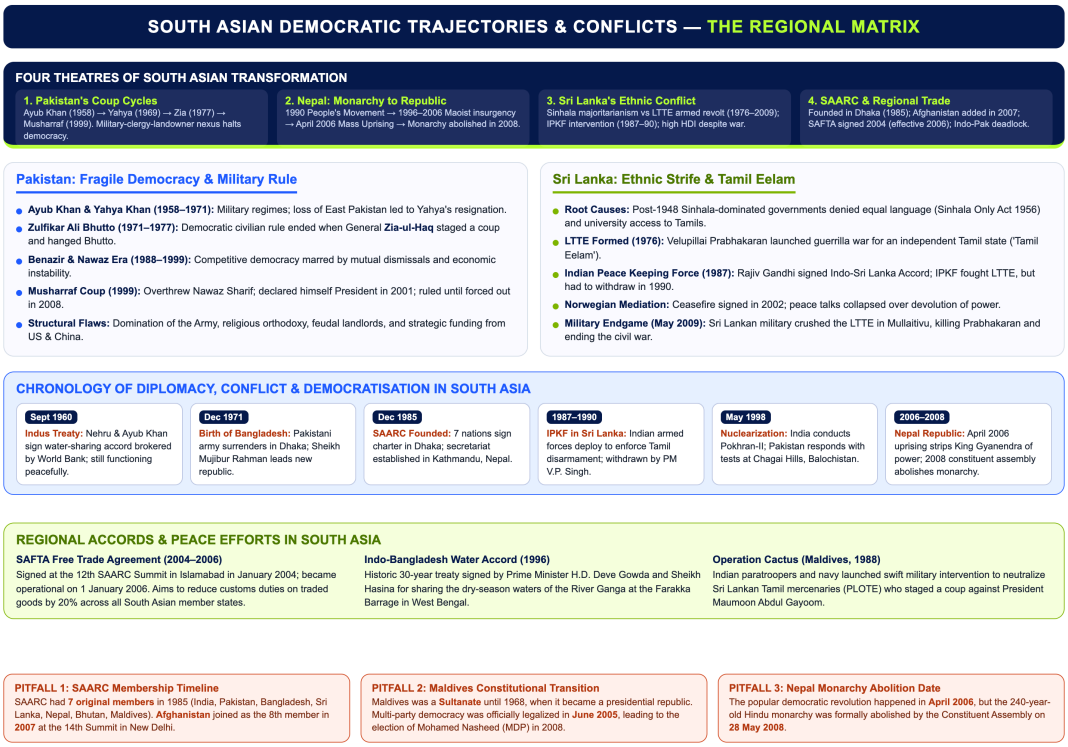



Figure 2: Figure 2 — Thematic Chronology & Regional Accords Architecture: Major diplomatic milestones, water-sharing treaties, nuclear milestones, and SAARC/SAFTA regional frameworks.

# 5. Sri Lanka: Ethnic Conflict, Majoritarianism and Economic Resilience

Sri Lanka (known as Ceylon until 1972) achieved independence from British rule in 1948. While it preserved uninterrupted democratic institutions and achieved stellar social development indicators, it was convulsed by a devastating ethnic civil war:

## The Roots of Ethnic Conflict: Sinhala Majoritarianism

- **Demographic Composition:** The island's population consists predominantly of the Buddhist **Sinhalese majority** (approximately 74%) and the **Tamil minority** (approximately 18%, comprising indigenous Sri Lankan Tamils and Indian Tamils brought by British planters).
- **Majoritarian Legislation:** Following independence, Sinhala-dominated political elites passed laws marginalizing Tamils:
  - **The Sinhala Only Act (1956):** Replaced English with Sinhala as the sole official language of the country, excluding Tamil speakers from civil service and judiciary appointments.
  - State colonization schemes altered demographics in the Northern and Eastern provinces, while university admission quotas disadvantaged Tamil students.

## The Rise of Armed Tamil Militancy and the LTTE

- **The Demand for Tamil Eelam:** Concluding that peaceful political protests were futile, Tamil youth turned to armed insurrection. In 1976, the **Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE)** was formed under the ruthless, charismatic leadership of **Velupillai Prabhakaran**, demanding an independent Tamil state (**Tamil Eelam**) in the North and East.

- **Civil War and Suicide Terrorism:** From 1983 onwards, Sri Lanka was engulfed in open civil war. The LTTE pioneered the deadly tactic of suicide bombing (using the **Black Tigers**), assassinated prominent political figures (including Sri Lankan President Ranasinghe Premadasa and former Indian Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi in 1991), and established a de facto state with its own courts, police, and naval wing (**Sea Tigers**) based in Jaffna and Kilinochchi.

### The Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF, 1987–1990)

- **The Indo-Sri Lanka Accord (July 1987):** Prime Minister Rajiv Gandhi and President J.R. Jayewardene signed an accord granting regional autonomy to the Tamil provinces (the 13th Amendment).
- **The Deployment:** India dispatched the **Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF)** to disarm the Tamil militants. However, the LTTE refused to surrender arms and fought the Indian Army. Simultaneously, Sinhalese nationalist parties and the JVP protested Indian military presence as an imperial invasion. Caught in a brutal crossfire, the IPKF was pulled out in **1990** by Prime Minister V.P. Singh without achieving its objectives.
- **The Military Denouement (May 2009):** Following the collapse of Norwegian-mediated peace talks in the mid-2000s, the Sri Lankan military launched a massive, unrelenting military offensive under President Mahinda Rajapaksa. In **May 2009**, the LTTE was decisively crushed, Prabhakaran was killed in battle, and the civil war officially ended.
- **Economic Resilience:** Despite three decades of civil war, Sri Lanka maintained high literacy rates (over 90%), low infant mortality, high life expectancy, and was the first South Asian country to liberalize its economy (in 1977).

## 6. Regional Bilateral Dynamics: India and Its Neighbors

India occupies the central geographical and economic position in South Asia, sharing borders with almost every other regional state, while none of the other states share borders with each other:

### India and Pakistan: Chronic Rivalry and Nuclear Standoff

- **Core Disputes:** Unresolved territorial dispute over **Jammu and Kashmir**, the militarized high-altitude standoff on the **Siachen Glacier**, maritime boundary delimitation in **Sir Creek**, and Pakistan's continued sponsorship of cross-border terrorism.
- **Nuclearization (May 1998):** India conducted five underground nuclear tests at **Pokhran** (Operation Shakti) on 11 and 13 May 1998. Pakistan responded within weeks by conducting six nuclear tests at the **Chagai Hills** in Balochistan on 28 and 30 May 1998, locking South Asia in a nuclear deterrence framework.
- **The Kargil War (May–July 1999):** Pakistani troops and infiltrators secretly occupied high-altitude bunker posts along the Line of Control (LoC) in the Kargil sector of Jammu and Kashmir. Indian armed forces mounted a ferocious counter-offensive (**Operation Vijay**), successfully reclaiming all occupied heights.
- **Confidence-Building Measures (CBMs):** Bilateral summits (Lahore 1999, Agra 2001), cultural exchanges, cricket diplomacy, and bus/train linkages (**Samjhauta Express**, **Thar Express**) have periodically eased tensions.

### India and Bangladesh: Cooperation and Irritants

- **Cooperation:** Historic 30-year **Ganga Water Sharing Treaty** signed in **1996** at Farakka; cooperation in counter-terrorism; transit rights for India's Northeast; and the landmark **2015 Land Boundary Agreement (LBA)** resolving long-standing border enclaves.

- **Irritants:** Differences over sharing the Teesta river waters, illegal migration, cattle smuggling, and natural gas export transit.

### India, Nepal, Bhutan, and the Maldives

- **Nepal and Bhutan:** Governed by historic 1950 Friendship Treaties, permitting citizens open borders, visa-free travel, and reciprocal employment. India is Bhutan's premier economic partner, financing immense hydroelectric power projects (Chukha, Tala, Mangdechhu).
- **The Maldives:** Close maritime and security partner. In **November 1988**, Indian paratroopers launched **Operation Cactus** within hours of a distress call from President Gayoom, neutralizing Sri Lankan Tamil mercenaries (PLOTE) who had staged a coup. India also provided emergency freshwater supplies during the 2014 Male desalination plant crisis.

## 7. Regional Multilateralism: SAARC, SAFTA & Institutional Hurdles

To promote regional collective self-reliance, South Asian nations established multilateral frameworks:

### SAARC: Genesis, Structure and Structural Gridlock

- **Founding in Dhaka (December 1985):** Founded by seven states, SAARC operates through annual summits of heads of state, with a permanent Secretariat based in **Kathmandu, Nepal**. In **2007**, **Afghanistan** was formally admitted as the eighth member.
- **Structural Weakness:** SAARC's charter mandates that decisions must be taken unanimously and that "bilateral and contentious issues" must be excluded from official deliberations. Consequently, ongoing political hostility between India and Pakistan has repeatedly derailed summits, paralyzing regional economic integration.

### SAFTA: The South Asian Free Trade Area

- **The Agreement:** Signed at the 12th SAARC Summit in Islamabad in **January 2004**, SAFTA entered into force on **1 January 2006**.
- **Objective:** Aims to lower customs duties across the region by 20% to stimulate intra-regional commerce. However, mutual trade suspicions and trade restrictions (especially Pakistan's reluctance to grant Most Favored Nation status to India) have kept intra-regional trade below 5% of South Asia's total global commerce.
- **Sub-Regional Alternatives:** Faced with SAARC's paralysis, India has turned increasingly to sub-regional groupings that exclude Pakistan, notably **BIMSTEC** (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) and BBIN (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal).

## 8. Hydro-Politics and Ecological Interdependence in South Asia

River systems across South Asia transcend national sovereign frontiers, rendering water sharing both a critical catalyst for regional cooperation and a persistent trigger of geopolitical friction:

### The Indus Water System: Bilateral Resilience Amidst Conflict

- **The Treaty Framework (1960):** Brokered by the International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (**World Bank**), the **Indus Waters Treaty (IWT)** was signed in Karachi on 19 September 1960 by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and Field Marshal Ayub Khan.
- **River Allocations:** The treaty allocated the three **Eastern Rivers** (Ravi, Beas, Sutlej) exclusively to India for unrestricted usage, while the three **Western Rivers** (Indus, Jhelum,

Chenab) were allocated to Pakistan, subject to India's permitted non-consumptive uses, run-of-the-river hydroelectric power projects, and limited agricultural storage.

- **Permanent Indus Commission (PIC):** Establishes mandatory regular bilateral consultations, data exchanges, and technical inspections, maintaining institutional continuity even during major wars (1965, 1971, 1999).

### The Ganga-Brahmaputra-Meghna Basin: Shared Challenges

- **The Farakka Barrage Dispute & 1996 Accord:** Constructed in 1975 to flush silt from the Kolkata Port, the Farakka Barrage previously generated severe dry-season water shortages in southwestern Bangladesh. In **December 1996**, Prime Ministers H.D. Deve Gowda and Sheikh Hasina concluded the historic 30-year **Ganga Water Sharing Treaty**, establishing a predictable volumetric release formula during the lean season (January to May).
- **The Teesta River Deadlock:** The Teesta river, originating in Sikkim and flowing through West Bengal into Bangladesh, remains a major unresolved issue due to concerns regarding seasonal water availability for northern West Bengal's agricultural irrigation.
- **Indo-Nepal Hydroelectric Cooperation:** The **Mahakali Treaty (1996)** governs the integrated development of the Sarada Barrage, Tanakpur Barrage, and the proposed Pancheshwar Multipurpose Project, though implementation has faced domestic political debates in Nepal.

## 9. Nuclear Deterrence, Border Security & Peace Diplomacy

The nuclear tests of May 1998 fundamentally transformed South Asia from a conventional military theater into an overt nuclearized security complex:

### Strategic Stability and Doctrine Asymmetry

- **The May 1998 Tests:** India conducted five underground nuclear explosions at **Pokhran** on 11 and 13 May 1998 (**Operation Shakti**). Pakistan responded on 28 and 30 May 1998 with six nuclear tests in the **Chagai Hills**, formally declaring nuclear weapon capability.
- **Doctrinal Divergence:** India adopted a formal **No First Use (NFU)** doctrine coupled with a posture of **Credible Minimum Deterrence**, committing never to use nuclear weapons against non-nuclear states. Conversely, Pakistan declined to adopt NFU, reserving the right to early nuclear first-use to offset India's conventional military superiority.
- **The 1999 Kargil Conflict:** Tested the "stability-instability paradox." Pakistani military incursions across the LoC triggered intense localized conventional warfare, which remained contained below the nuclear threshold due to Indian restraint and international diplomatic pressure.

### Sub-Regionalism as a Paradigm Shift: Beyond SAARC Gridlock

- **The Stagnation of SAARC:** Due to structural paralysis caused by bilateral Indo-Pak tensions —culminating in the indefinite postponement of the 19th SAARC Summit scheduled for Islamabad in 2016 following the Uri terrorist attack—India pivoted toward sub-regional multilateralism.
- **BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative):** Established via the 1997 Bangkok Declaration, BIMSTEC bridges South Asia and Southeast Asia (comprising India, Bangladesh, Bhutan, Nepal, Sri Lanka, Myanmar, and Thailand). It offers an integrated regional platform free from Pakistani vetoes.
- **BBIN Sub-Regional Framework:** The Bangladesh-Bhutan-India-Nepal initiative pioneered the **BBIN Motor Vehicles Agreement (2015)** to operationalize seamless cross-border

vehicular transit, cargo freight logistics, and sub-regional energy grid integration across the eastern subcontinent.

## Track-II Diplomacy, Cultural Linkages and Civil Society Initiatives

- **People-to-People Contacts:** Beyond formal state diplomacy, South Asian peace initiatives rely heavily on "Track-II" (non-governmental) dialogues involving retired diplomats, military officers, academics, and journalists.
- **Cultural & Humanitarian Bridges:** Initiatives such as the **Nehru-Wangchuck Cultural Centre**, cross-border religious pilgrimages (the Kartarpur Sahib Corridor opened in 2019 connecting Indian Punjab to Pakistan's Narowal district), joint disaster relief operations, and educational exchanges (such as the **South Asian University** established in New Delhi by SAARC member states) provide critical social resilience against diplomatic breakdowns.
- **Shared Ecological Vulnerability:** From melting Himalayan glaciers that feed the Indus and Brahmaputra river systems to rising sea levels threatening the low-lying atolls of the Maldives and the deltaic coastline of Bangladesh, climate vulnerability forms a shared trans-boundary imperative requiring coordinated regional climate adaptation strategies.

## Geo-Strategic Balancing: External Powers in South Asia

- **The Role of the United States:** The United States remains deeply engaged in South Asia, maintaining strategic defense and economic partnerships with India while historically maintaining military assistance ties with Pakistan. Since 2000, US-India bilateral trade and strategic alignment (such as the 2008 Civil Nuclear Agreement) have expanded dramatically.
- **The Chinese Dimension:** Although China is geographically an East Asian power, its burgeoning economic and military presence across South Asia—through infrastructure loans and port developments under the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) in Gwadar (Pakistan), Hambantota (Sri Lanka), and Chittagong (Bangladesh)—remains a key structural factor influencing regional balance of power calculations.

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# Chapter Synthesis & Cognitive Mindmap




Figure 3: Figure 3 — Contemporary South Asia Summary Mindmap: Complete structural map of democratisation in Pakistan and Bangladesh, Nepal's republic transition, Sri Lanka's ethnic conflict, bilateral ties, and SAARC/SAFTA integration.

## HIGH-YIELD MEMORY HOOKS & HISTORIOGRAPHICAL POINTERS

- **Indus Waters Treaty (1960):** Brokered by the **World Bank**; signed by Nehru and Ayub Khan; remains functional despite wars.
- **Birth of Bangladesh:** Surrender of Pakistani forces on **16 December 1971**; Awami League led by Sheikh Mujibur Rahman.
- **SAARC Founding Date & Secretariat:** Founded in **Dhaka (Dec 1985)**; permanent Secretariat is in **Kathmandu, Nepal**.
- **8th Member of SAARC: Afghanistan** joined in **2007** at the 14th Summit in New Delhi.
- **SAFTA Operational Date:** Signed in 2004; became operational on **1 January 2006**.
- **Nepal's Monarchy Abolished: 2008** Constituent Assembly abolished 240-year monarchy, establishing a secular republic.
- **Maldives Transition:** Sultanate transformed to republic in **1968**; multi-party democracy legalized in **June 2005**.
- **Operation Cactus (1988):** Indian military intervention to crush mercenary coup in the Maldives.

### MASTER STRATEGY CHEATSHEET — CONTEMPORARY SOUTH ASIA

▶**South Asia Scope:** 8 nations (India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, Maldives, Afghanistan). China is NOT part of South Asia. ▶**Pakistan's Coups:** Ayub Khan (1958) → Yahya Khan (1969) → Zia-ul-Haq (1977) → Pervez Musharraf (1999). ▶**Bangladesh Trajectory:** 1952 Language Movement → 1970 Elections (Awami League) → 1971 Liberation War → 1975 BAKSAL & Mujib assassination → 1991 Multi-party democracy restored. ▶**Nepal Republic Milestones:** 1990 Constitutional Monarchy → 1996–2006 Maoist Insurgency → 2001 Palace Massacre → 2005 Gyanendra Coup → 2006 April Democracy Uprising → 2008 Monarchy Abolished. ▶**Sri Lanka Conflict:** Sinhala Only Act (1956) → LTTE founded 1976 by Prabhakaran → IPKF (1987–1990) → Rajiv Gandhi assassinated (1991) → Military defeat of LTTE (May 2009). ▶**Regional Treaties:** Indus Treaty (1960); Farakka Ganga Accord (1996); SAFTA (2004/2006); Gujral Doctrine (1996); Operation Cactus (1988).

### THE SEVEN FATAL CUET TRAPS

1. **Trap 1 (China as South Asian State):** Assuming China belongs to South Asia because it shares borders. China is an East Asian state; it is NOT a South Asian state!
2. **Trap 2 (SAARC Founding vs Headquarters):** SAARC was founded in **Dhaka (1985)**, but its permanent headquarters/secretariat is in **Kathmandu, Nepal**.
3. **Trap 3 (Afghanistan SAARC Membership Year):** Afghanistan was NOT an original 1985 member; it joined as the 8th member in **2007**.
4. **Trap 4 (SAFTA Signing vs Operational Year):** SAFTA was signed in **January 2004** in Islamabad; it became operational on **1 January 2006**.
5. **Trap 5 (Maldives Republic vs Multi-Party Year):** Maldives became a republic in **1968**; multi-party democracy was introduced in **June 2005**.
6. **Trap 6 (Indus Waters Treaty Mediator):** Believing the UN mediated the Indus Waters Treaty. It was mediated by the **World Bank** in 1960.
7. **Trap 7 (IPKF Departure Year):** Indian Peace Keeping Force was sent in **1987** by Rajiv Gandhi and completely withdrawn in **1990** by Prime Minister V.P. Singh.

# Exam-Style Practice Questions & Detailed Solutions

## Part 1: Regional Scope, Water Treaties & SAARC Genesis (Q1 to Q5)

**Q1.** The historic Indus Waters Treaty, which has successfully governed water sharing between India and Pakistan since 1960, was brokered by which international institution?

(A) The United Nations Security Council
(B) The World Bank
(C) The International Monetary Fund
(D) The Asian Development Bank

**Sol. Q1.** Indus Waters Treaty Mediator:

- The **Indus Waters Treaty** was brokered by the **World Bank** and signed on 19 September 1960 by Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru and President Ayub Khan.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

**Q2.** In which year was the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) formally launched at its first summit held in Dhaka, Bangladesh?

(A) 1980
(B) 1982
(C) 1985
(D) 1988

**Sol. Q2.** Founding of SAARC:

- SAARC was established on **8 December 1985** in **Dhaka** by seven founding members: India, Pakistan, Bangladesh, Nepal, Bhutan, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

**Q3.** Which sovereign state was formally inducted as the eighth official member of SAARC at the 14th SAARC Summit held in New Delhi in 2007?

(A) Afghanistan
(B) Myanmar
(C) Mauritius
(D) Tibet

**Sol. Q3.** Eighth Member of SAARC:

- **Afghanistan** became the eighth member of SAARC in **2007** during the 14th Summit in New Delhi. Myanmar and China hold observer status only.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

**Q4.** Signed at the 12th SAARC Summit in Islamabad in 2004, on which date did the South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA) agreement officially come into operation?

(A) 1 January 2004
(B) 1 April 2005
(C) 15 August 2005
(D) 1 January 2006

**Sol. Q4.** Operational Date of SAFTA:

- The SAFTA agreement was signed in January 2004 and came into operational effect on **1 January 2006**, aiming to reduce regional customs tariffs by 20%.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

**Q5.** In 1996, India and Bangladesh resolved a protracted dispute over sharing the dry-season waters of the River Ganga at Farakka Barrage by signing a historic treaty for a duration of:

(A) 30 years
(B) 10 years
(C) 20 years
(D) 50 years

**Sol. Q5.** Indo-Bangladesh Ganga Water Accord:

- In **December 1996**, Prime Ministers H.D. Deve Gowda and Sheikh Hasina signed the historic **30-year Ganga Water Sharing Treaty** at Farakka.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

## Part 2: Nepal Republic, Military Regimes & Peace Accords (Q6 to Q10)

**Q6.** In 2008, following the massive Seven-Party Alliance and Maoist popular uprising of April 2006, the newly elected Constituent Assembly of Nepal voted to:

(A) Abolish the 240-year-old Hindu monarchy and establish a federal democratic republic
(B) Restore the autocratic absolute powers of King Gyanendra
(C) Merge Nepal's foreign and defense administration with India
(D) Adopt a one-party communist dictatorship modeled on China

**Sol. Q6.** Abolition of the Nepalese Monarchy:

- In **May 2008**, Nepal's newly elected Constituent Assembly officially **abolished the 240-year-old monarchy**, transforming Nepal into a secular, federal democratic republic.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

**Q7.** Which Pakistani army chief ousted Prime Minister Nawaz Sharif in a bloodless military coup in October 1999, subsequently ruling as President until 2008?

(A) General Zia-ul-Haq
(B) General Pervez Musharraf
(C) General Ayub Khan
(D) General Yahya Khan

**Sol. Q7.** Musharraf's Military Coup:

- **General Pervez Musharraf** staged a military coup on **12 October 1999**, deposing Nawaz Sharif and ruling as military leader and President until 2008.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

**Q8.** In November 1988, what was the code name of the swift Indian military intervention that neutralized Sri Lankan Tamil mercenaries attempting a coup in the Maldives?

(A) Operation Meghdoot
(B) Operation Vijay
(C) Operation Cactus
(D) Operation Pawan

**Sol. Q8.** Operation Cactus (1988):

- **Operation Cactus** was launched in **November 1988** by Indian paratroopers and naval forces to rescue President Maumoon Abdul Gayoom from a mercenary coup in the Maldives.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

**Q9.** In which year was the Indian Peace Keeping Force (IPKF) dispatched to Sri Lanka under the Rajiv Gandhi–Jayewardene Accord to disarm Tamil militants?

(A) 1983
(B) 1985
(C) 1989
(D) 1987

**Sol. Q9.** Deployment of the IPKF:

- The IPKF was deployed in **July 1987** under the Indo-Sri Lanka Accord. Following fierce conflict with the LTTE, it was withdrawn by Prime Minister V.P. Singh in **1990**.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

**Q10.** Which Indian foreign policy doctrine, formulated in 1996, asserted that India should extend unilateral, non-reciprocal concessions to its smaller South Asian neighbors?

(A) The Nehru Doctrine
(B) The Gujral Doctrine
(C) The Indira Doctrine
(D) The Vajpayee Consensus

**Sol. Q10.** The Gujral Doctrine (1996):

- Formulated by I.K. Gujral, the **Gujral Doctrine** emphasized that India must grant non-reciprocal concessions and economic assistance to its smaller neighbors in good faith.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

## Part 3: Island Transitions, Nuclear Tests & LTTE Defeat (Q11 to Q15)

**Q11.** The island nation of the Maldives was governed as an Islamic Sultanate until which year, when it formally transformed into a presidential republic?

(A) 1952 (B) 1965
(C) 1968 (D) 1988

**Sol. Q11.** Maldives Constitutional Transition:

- The Maldives was a Sultanate until **1968**, when it adopted a presidential republic. Multi-party democracy was subsequently legalized in **June 2005**.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**

**Q12.** In May 1998, in response to India's underground nuclear tests at Pokhran, Pakistan conducted its own nuclear detonations in which mountainous region?

(A) Chagai Hills (Balochistan) (B) Khyber Pass (Khyber Pakhtunkhwa)
(C) Sulaiman Range (Punjab) (D) Hindu Kush (Gilgit-Baltistan)

**Sol. Q12.** Pakistan's Nuclear Tests:

- Pakistan conducted six nuclear tests on 28 and 30 May 1998 in the **Chagai Hills** of Balochistan, establishing mutual nuclear deterrence with India.

Therefore, Option A is the correct answer. **Answer: (A)**

**Q13.** Under the visionary leadership of King Jigme Khesar Namgyel Wangchuck, in which year did Bhutan hold its first historic multi-party democratic elections?

(A) 1998 (B) 2002
(C) 2005 (D) 2008

**Sol. Q13.** Democratisation in Bhutan:

- **Bhutan** held its first multi-party parliamentary elections in **March 2008**, successfully transitioning from an absolute monarchy into a constitutional democracy.

Therefore, Option D is the correct answer. **Answer: (D)**

**Q14.** The militant separatist organization Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), which fought for an independent homeland for Sri Lankan Tamils, was founded by:

(A) Douglas Devananda (B) Velupillai Prabhakaran
(C) S.J.V. Chelvanayakam (D) A. Amirthalingam

**Sol. Q14.** Leadership of the LTTE:

- **Velupillai Prabhakaran** founded the LTTE in **1976**, leading an armed guerrilla campaign for Tamil Eelam until his death in battle in May 2009.

Therefore, Option B is the correct answer. **Answer: (B)**

**Q15.** The permanent headquarters and official Secretariat of the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) is situated in which capital city?

(A) Dhaka, Bangladesh (B) New Delhi, India
(C) Kathmandu, Nepal (D) Colombo, Sri Lanka

**Sol. Q15.** Secretariat of SAARC:

- While SAARC was founded in Dhaka in 1985, its permanent Secretariat is located in **Kathmandu, Nepal**.

Therefore, Option C is the correct answer. **Answer: (C)**